Charles B. Cousar. An Introduction to the New Testament: Witness to God's New Work. Louisville; London: Westminster John Knox Press, 2006.

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Introduction to the Synoptic Gospels

The Gospel is a second genre of Christian literature quite different than the letter. The first four books of the New Testament are labeled "Gospels," though there exists a marked difference between the first three and the fourth. The fourth has personnel and events that do not exist in the first three, whereas the first three contain and share among themselves material not found in the fourth. We shall take a careful look at the Gospel of Mark and then take note of distinctive features of the Gospels of Matthew and Luke. The Gospel of John will be treated with the three letters of John as the prominent document of the Johannine tradition.

The earliest example is the Gospel of Mark, written about 65–70 CE, and circulated widely within approximately two decades after its composition.[1] Matthew and Luke clearly borrow material from Mark, and yet they do not displace Mark because they remain distinct stories (and thus the phrase "Synoptic Gospels"). That is, Matthew and Luke do not reproduce Mark's story or dialogue in such detail as to render Mark or either of them redundant. In addition, there is a considerable amount of material that obviously Matthew and Luke share. This is called Q (from the German word for "source," *quelle*). Not all scholars accept the hypothesis of Q, but its presence (or lack thereof) will make no difference to our study since we are dealing primarily with the material in its canonical form. Toward the end of the twentieth century, redaction criticism and, following it, literary criticism have made it clear that each Gospel is more than a collection of isolated units of material but tells a consistent and comprehensible story. *

The Gospel tradition seems to have gone through several stages of oral transmission between the time when Jesus lived and taught and the time when

the Gospels were written. Most of the disciples, as well as Jesus, spoke Aramaic, though undoubtedly there were a few Greek-speaking Jews mingled in the various communities. Since Greek was the lingua franca of the day, it rapidly took over as the prominent tongue for preaching and teaching the faith, especially for an urban person like the apostle Paul.

After Rome routed the Jewish rebellion in 70 CE, the churches became increasingly Gentile and less Jewish. In fact, Jews who were Christians were dismissed from the synagogues and subjected to considerable persecution.

While the Gospels were primarily written for and circulated among Christian communities, there is increasing recognition that they had a missionary function as well and were read by non-Christians. Particularly in the second century, various apologists suggested that non-Christians read the Gospels. The critic Celsus's (180 CE) attack on Christianity reveals an acquaintance with the Gospels,[2] and Justin states that Trypho learned of the Christian faith by having read "the so-called Gospel."[3] A careful crafting of the literary narratives further suggests that a wider dissemination was intended than the small congregations for which they were written.

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The Gospel of Mark

The evangelist Mark took the tradition that came to his hand, and without dispensing with his original sources, fashioned a powerful new voice to proclaim the good news, the story of the gift of God's newness. He creatively molded his sources into a comprehensive whole. The questions are: what is that whole, and what does it say to its implied audience.

MARK 1:1–3:6

Mark has no story of Jesus' birth, no account of his childhood. Instead we first meet Jesus as an adult figure, receiving the baptism of his cousin John. Four items are significant about the beginning of the Gospel:

1. The use of the expression "the beginning of the gospel" (or "good news," 1:1) elicits the uses of the word in Isaiah (cf 40:9; 52:7; 61:1). The "beginning" implies not merely the start of the narrative, but its basis or foundation, which continues to be preached, even in Mark's story (13:10; 14:9). In the early church, the term "gospel" had taken on special significance from its frequency in the Pauline letters, where it denotes the church's preaching of Jesus as the source of salvation. Stanton has made the case that the word "gospel" is heard against the backdrop of a rival set of "gospels" in the ancient world and thus is a risky word to use in light of the imperial cult of Rome.[1]

The titles attached are appropriate: "Jesus Christ, the Son of God." "Christ"—that is, Messiah—appears in Mark regularly as an honorific or messianic title (8:29; 12:35; 13:21; 14:61; 15:32), while at other times it appears as a regular name for Jesus (9:41). "Son of God," on the other hand, is used only

at pivotal moments—at his baptism (1:11), on the mount of transfiguration (9:7), and at his trial (14:61).

2. Mark's reference to Jesus' baptism is terse but striking (1:9–11). As John leads Jesus up from the water and the Spirit descends on him, the heavens are torn asunder, and the voice speaks from the skies, "You are my Son, the Beloved; with you I am well pleased." Whereas in Matthew's and Luke's accounts of the baptism the expression is simply "the heavens *opened*," Mark uses a different (and more violent) verb, suggesting a translation such as "he saw the heavens *torn apart*."

Don Juel has called attention to the parallel between the tearing of the heavens in 1:9–11 and the rending of the temple curtain in 15:38–39. "The elimination of a barrier between God and creation, clearest in the tearing of the temple curtain, may be suggested in the baptismal scene as well." The implications are that we have a new access to the Father, because "the protecting barriers are gone, and that God, unwilling to be confined to sacred spaces, is on the loose in our own realm. If characters in the story find Jesus' ministry threatening, then they may have good reason to be frightened by his resurrection."[2]

3. The story begins abruptly and assumes a fast pace. Following the description of John, we read immediately of the baptism of Jesus (1:9–11), the temptation of Jesus (1:12–13), the beginning of Jesus' ministry in Galilee (1:14–15), the call of four of the disciples (1:16–20), and in rapid-fire succession, the healing of a man possessed of a demon (1:21–28), the healing of Peter's mother-in-law (1:29–31), a summary account of Jesus' exorcism (1:32–34), a brief report of Jesus' preaching tour throughout Galilee (1:35–39), and Jesus' cleansing of a leper (1:40–45). This frequent succession of events continues throughout the entire story. Nothing slows the pace of the narrative, as in Matthew (e.g., a genealogy and three chapters of the Sermon on the Mount) or in Luke (e.g., lengthy birth narratives and a genealogy). The rapidity of Mark heightens the urgency of the story.

4. The declaration of Jesus' preaching the gospel (1:14) and his announcement that the time has been fulfilled and that the kingdom of God has come near (1:15a) are paramount. The termination of the old age and the inbreaking of the new age are proclaimed, calling for repentance and an act of faith. At each baptism the believer would hear "this announcement of cosmic juncture as a promise that they might now enter the dominion of God . . . and as a call to bury the moribund world in the water and to rise from it to view, through the eyes of faith, God's new creation."[3]

Next follows a series of events that disclose the authority and power of Jesus—in calling disciples to leave behind their work, in exorcizing demons, in healing the sick, in cleansing a leper. As the astonished crowd puts it, "What is this? A new teaching—with authority! He commands even the unclean spirits, and they obey him" (1:27b). God's sovereign power has come near. The radical *novum* is at hand.

The second chapter of the Gospel discloses the opposition that begins to build against Jesus. Mark relates a series of controversy stories (2:1–12, 15–17, 18–20, 23–27), culminating with a plot on the part of the Pharisees and Herodians to destroy Jesus (3:6).

At the center of this section, people question Jesus: "Why do John's disciples and the disciples of the Pharisees fast, but your disciples do not fast?" (2:18). Jesus responds that the wedding guests do not fast as long as the bridegroom is with them. Only during the days when the bridegroom is taken from them will they fast.

Then Jesus relates two brief parables. "No one sews a piece of unshrunk cloth on an old cloak; otherwise, the patch pulls away from it, the new from the old, and a worse tear is made. And no one puts new wine into old wineskins; otherwise, the wine will burst the skins, and the wine is lost, and so are the skins; but one puts new wine into fresh wineskins" (2:21–22). What we have seen in the narrative is the conflict between the dynamic of the new era and the inherited religious practices of the old age. The evangelist makes clear that Jesus cannot really be understood, except by embracing the new era and by abandoning the old. "The old order, then, must sooner or later take away Jesus' life, because he has violently disturbed it with his new teaching, which tears at its very fabric."[4] So we encounter the build-up to 3:6, where the conspiracy to destroy Jesus begins to take shape.

MARK 3:7–8:26

This section also strongly defines who is an insider and who is an outsider. The crowds follow Jesus from all over Galilee "in great numbers" (3:7–8). But Jesus selects and appoints twelve disciples to be with him and to be sent out to exorcize demons, to heal the sick, and to preach the good news. Pretty soon, they begin to encounter opposition themselves; and at the same time, Jesus faces two charges: one made by the religious authorities of his joining into a confederacy with the demons ("He has Beelzebul" [3:22]); and the other made by his family ("He has gone out of his mind" [3:21]).

First, Jesus responds to the criticism of his family, who ironically end up being on the outside. He looks at those who are sitting around him and says, "Whoever does the will of God is my brother and sister and mother" (3:35).

In two brief parables Jesus responds to those who accuse him of being in league with Satan by raising the question of a house being divided against itself ("That house will not be able to stand" [3:25]). Moreover, if one wants

to plunder a person's house, he has to tie up the person first and then he can thoroughly ransack the house. The exorcisms and healings are the plundering of Satan's house by the "more powerful" one (1:7). Jesus is currently doing just that—that is, tying up the strong man and raiding Satan's kingdom.[5]

Mark now draws together several of Jesus' parables, which represent the major unit of teaching in the Gospel. The parables in the fourth chapter have to do with the complexities and variations of hearing the word of God. Note that at the beginning and ending of the first parable the reader is strongly advised to "listen" (4:3, 9).

1. Mark begins with the parable of the sower (4:2–9) and its interpretation (4:13–20). While the sower sows seeds that fall on the path and on the rocky ground and amid the thorns, nevertheless, one-fourth of the seed yields a surprising crop. Jeremias has noted that a tenfold yield was considered a good harvest.[6] Here the yield is extraordinary . . . thirty, sixty, and a hundredfold! The one who proclaims the word of God is bound to be encouraged by such results.

2. The secret of the kingdom (4:10–12) represents one of the most difficult of the New Testament interpretive problems and one we will not solve here. Citing Isaiah 6:9–10, the saying seems to summarize the purpose and not the result of the preaching of the kingdom, though it is particularly vulnerable to a deterministic reading. For those on the inside the parables reveal the mystery of the kingdom, whereas for the outsiders, the parables only hide and do not reveal.[7]

3. The symbol of light (4:21–25), with its inherent revelatory character, encourages the reader, whereas the word about "the measure you give will be the measure you get," tends to issue a warning about the risks of discipleship.

4. The parable of the seed growing secretly (4:26–29) stresses the mystery of growth and the reality that God's critical times occur spontaneously, independent of human activity and contributions. "The earth produces of itself" (the Greek: *automatē*, 4:28).

5. The parable of the mustard seed (4:30–32) offers a promise: from small beginnings the kingdom of God will emerge to become cosmic in scope, as the largest of all the bushes in the garden. The birds of the air will rest in the branches of the tree, where they are protected, as promised (Ezek 17:23; 31:6; Dan 4:12, 21).

Mark then extends Jesus' ministry as a worker of mighty deeds by presenting a number of dramatic events in which he stilled the uncontrollable storm (4:35–41); he exorcised the demon who had plagued the Gerasene man and had left him stranded in the tombs (5:1–20); he healed the woman who had been troubled by perpetual hemorrhaging (5:21–34); and he raised Jairus's daughter (5:1–20, 35–43).

This section of mighty deeds done by Jesus ends not with an acknowledgment or acceptance of his works by his townspeople, but by a total rejection by his relatives, heightened by the narrator's comment, "And he was amazed at their unbelief" (6:1–6a). Such a negative reaction to Jesus foreshadows the death of John the Baptist (6:14–29). Moreover, Herod's misuse of power (6:20, 26) anticipates a similar misuse by Pilate (15:6–15).

The two feedings of the multitudes, initially five thousand (6:30–44) and then four thousand (8:1–9), remind readers of the provision of manna in the wilderness (cf. Exod 16:13–35; Num 11:1–35) and foreshadow the supper Jesus will eat with his disciples in the upper room (taking, blessing, breaking the loaves). Jesus' further care for individuals, such as the Syrophoenician woman (7:24–30) and the deaf mute (7:31–37), characterizes his ministry.

The most striking feature of this section comes in the closing incident when Jesus heals a blind man at Bethsaida (8:21–26). Rather than being an instantaneous event as most of Jesus' healings were, this blind man was cured in two stages. First, Jesus put saliva on his hand and touched the man's eyes. He was able to see "people as if they were trees walking." But then Jesus repeated the process, "and he saw everything." Intriguingly, this passage does not appear in the Common Lectionary, though in many respects it reflects the more normal experience of those who come to see the gospel at first but only gradually.

MARK 8:27–10:45

A significant change in the narrative occurs at 8:27, with the stress falling on Jesus' upcoming suffering, the disciples' misunderstanding, and Jesus' instruction in discipleship. Peter's confession of Jesus as Messiah (8:29) contains no new information for Jesus; however, the implied readers of the Gospel begin to learn something new that had only been hinted at previously—namely, that suffering and death are critical to who Jesus is as Messiah. Three times they are told of his upcoming rejection, death, and resurrection (8:27–31; 9:31; 10:32–34). Tannehill calls these passion predictions "antithetical aphorisms."[8] By that he means that prior to this time the implied reader has been allowed to form an understanding of the author's view of Jesus in which suffering and death have had no major role. Only hints here and there have been given. Furthermore, the story of the Messiah the readers know—that is, the Davidic Messiah—was not a story of rejection and death. But now the contrast is sharp, the dissonance is harsh, even paradoxical.

> They assert a necessary connection between opposite terms. The attempt to save one's life will lead to the opposite; the goal of being first can only be achieved by its opposite. The clash of words in each of these antithetical aphorisms emphasizes the conflict between this

> vision of life and the normal view, in which people assume that they can directly achieve the goals that their anxious self-concern sets for them. These paradoxical words intend to shake the assumptions that normally control our thinking and planning.[9]

Furthermore, on this journey from Caesarea Philippi to Jerusalem, the disciples are taught the ABCs of what it means to follow Jesus. For example, the disciples argue as to who is the greatest, and Jesus settles the dispute by placing a little child in their midst and directing them to welcome such a one (9:33–37), and soon thereafter Jesus receives and blesses little children (10:13–16). In contrast to the role of the little child, the rich young man is unable to be freed of his wealth and thus is unable to follow Jesus (10:17–22). These demands of discipleship ("antithetical aphorisms"?) are all set in an eschatological context. At the final judgment those who suffer unjustly will be vindicated, and those who reject and are ashamed of Jesus and his teaching will be rejected and unknown (8:38).

MARK 11:1–16:8

Martin Kähler's famous comment that "one could call the Gospels passion narratives with extended introductions" is both inadequate and at the same time highly revelatory with respect to Mark.[10] Kähler's quote is inadequate in that events in the first thirteen chapters of Mark are not merely preliminary or introductory. In Mark, the events from the time of Peter's confession of Jesus as Messiah at Caesarea Philippi (8:29) up to the triumphal entry into Jerusalem are heavy laden with themes and predictions of the future. The three passion predictions and their implications for discipleship dominate the Gospel from at least its midpoint to the end. And yet Kähler's quote reveals the heavy emphasis placed on the passion narrative. Bartlett writes:

> More than any of the other Gospels, Mark's Gospel shows us how the crucifixion wounded God; how in Jesus Christ the suffering of God joins the suffering of humankind; how from now until all eternity God bears in God's heart that suffering and loss, like a scar, like a tree. If the great puzzle of Mark's Gospel is that Christ's death is the sign of Christ's sonship and God's love, the smaller puzzle is like unto it, human life is most alive when we, too, follow in the way of the cross. [11]

Following the cleansing of the temple at Jerusalem, the text lists a number of stories of conflict, all taking place within the context of the temple. The list begins with a challenge to Jesus' authority (11:27–33). After all, Jesus has just run the moneychangers out of the temple and disrupted their business. What

right did he have to do this? He first toys with them regarding the source of his authority by raising the issue of John's baptism, but then tells the parable of the Wicked Tenants (12:1–12), where "they" get the point but are trapped by the crowds and cannot make a move against him (12:12). Again, with his answer to the question about paying taxes to the emperor, they have no comeback (12:13–17).

When the Sadducees raise the foolish issue concerning whose wife will this childless widow be, they are exposed as people who do not believe in the resurrection in the first place (12:18–27). The conversation with the scribe turns out in a positive way, as Jesus confirms his response and commends him personally (12:28–34). In fact, Jesus' "praise of the scribe is Mark's way of acknowledging Christianity's debt to Judaism. Its most basic commands are the same."[12]

Jesus, having been queried by individuals and by groups, now takes the opportunity to question the scribes and, using Psalm 110:1, to declare the relation of the Messiah to the Son of David. "This incident reflects the theology of the Markan church that, while affirming Jesus' Davidic origin and messianic mission, rejects popular messianic expectations and redefines them in terms of the exaltation of Jesus above his enemies."[13]

The events that have occurred in and around the temple reach their climax with the prediction of the destruction of the temple (13:1–2) and the apocalyptic instruction that follows (13:3–31). Throughout the chapter the reader is faced with various warnings ("Beware!"). First, there is a group of the warnings spoken to those in the community who must face the false prophets and messiahs who say, "I am he!" Mark declares, "But the end is still to come. . . . This is but the beginning of the birthpangs" (13:5–8).

A second group of warnings is also directed at the community, but in terms of its mission and life (13:9–13). "Beware; for they will hand you over to councils; and you will be beaten in synagogues. . . . The gospel must first be proclaimed to all nations. . . . The one who endures to the end will be saved." The church's mission is carried on but always in the light of the cross.

A third set of warnings comes in the parable of the Doorkeeper, who is assigned the responsibility of watching for the return of the landlord (13:33–37). "Keep alert; for you do not know when the time will come. . . . Keep awake!" Vigilance and accountability are essential characteristics of faithfulness to the gospel and its mission.

Despite these warnings about apocalyptic enthusiasm and eagerness, chapter 13 reaffirms an apocalyptic expectation.

> So, too, God's hour comes unimpeded. He made the decisive beginning, the seed has been sown. He leaves nothing undone. . . . His beginning ripens to its fulfillment. Till then it behooves man [and

> woman] to wait in patience and not try to anticipate God but in full confidence to leave everything to him.[14]

Chapters 14 and 15 relate the last few days of Jesus' life. The pace of the story slows dramatically as Mark describes the anointing at Bethany, the extensive plots to do away with Jesus, and the various trials he has to undergo.

Four events, prior to the crucifixion, are most critical for our understanding of the passion story. The first is Jesus' anointing at Bethany by the unnamed woman (14:3–9). When her extravagance was questioned by some of the bystanders, Jesus defended her by saying that she "had anointed his body" ahead of time for his burial. Jesus did not deny that the poor were present in the world and needed food. Jesus would not need anointing at the normal time—namely, after he had died—because God would raise him from the dead. Moreover, "wherever the gospel is proclaimed in the whole world, what she has done will be told in remembrance of her" (14:9).

The second critical event is the Passover meal, which Jesus shared with his disciples, and at which he instituted the Lord's Supper (14:12–25). The verbs ("took," "blessed," " broke," "gave") are reminiscent of the two feedings previously reported in the Gospel (6:30–42; 8:1–10); however, the imagery points forward as well as backward. The vow Jesus spoke over the cup puts it clearly, "I will never drink again of the fruit of the vine until that day when I drink it new in the kingdom of God" (14:25). This future of the kingdom of God stands in tension with the programmatic announcement at the beginning of the Gospel, "The time is fulfilled; the kingdom of God has come" (1:15). Or as William Manson put it, "There is a realized eschatology. There is also an eschatology of the unrealized."[15] The adjective "proleptic" has come into common use to describe this predicament.[16] Jesus is troubled and distressed and even prays that the cup might be taken from him. "Abba," he calls to his Father, "yet, not what I want, but what you want" (14:36).

The word "Abba" is probably not to be understood as the intimate term "Daddy,"[17] but it certainly represents a distinctive and therefore remembered term (cf. Gal 4:6; Rom 8:15). Mark 14:36 is the only use of the term by Jesus. Jesus' prayer is set in the context of God's power to accomplish what God wants and of Jesus' obedience to the Father's will. What ensues is the mystery of human suffering met by the mystery of divine faithfulness and love.

Jesus' final expression in Mark's Gospel prior to his death is the cry of dereliction, "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" (15:34). Taunted by his enemies, abandoned by his disciples, and mocked by the soldiers, he resorts to his mother tongue and to the Scriptures (Ps 22:1).

Is this a cry of despair, a loud cry of one who in his death struggle with evil fears he is on the brink of defeat? Or is it a confession of faith in God's power

to overcome the forces of darkness and evil, even when things look bleak? Could Jesus have had in mind the rest of Psalm 22, with its positive ending? Countless scholars through the years have debated these questions, arriving at differing conclusions.[18] Brown, having tracked the arguments both pro and con, offers a fitting conclusion. Jesus naturally feels forsaken. "It was not in rage but in prayer that Jesus screamed his loud cry, even as the martyrs in Rev. 6:10 shouted with a loud cry their prayer for God to intervene."[19]

> His "Why?" is that of someone who has plumbed the depths of the abyss and feels enveloped by the power of darkness. Jesus is not questioning the existence of God or the power of God to do something about what is happening; he is questioning the silence of the one whom he called "My God."[20]

Martin Hengel has done a thorough study of the practice of crucifixion in the ancient world. Interestingly, he chose as the study's title the three Latin words used first by Origen, *mors turpissima cruces*, (the utterly vile death of the cross).[21] Not only was the pain hideously intense, but also the death carried with it shame and humiliation. A crucified Messiah, that seems to be a contradiction in terms, lies at the heart of Mark's Gospel.

Mark's depiction of the crucifixion, however, is realistic and to the point. It is not overdone. There is no glorification of suffering, as if Jesus had to endure the most pain of any individual ever if he were to bear humanity's sin. The atonement is not built on a quantitative notion, that the more one suffers the better she or he will be.

Mark articulates two responses to the crucifixion that are highly instructive. First, the temple curtain that separated the Holy of Holies from the outer court was ripped (the same violent verb Mark used for the tearing of the heavens at Jesus' baptism, 1:10) from top to bottom. The ripping of the curtain symbolizes the climax of the anti-temple strand that has run through the Gospel. The tearing of the curtain symbolized "the end of the exclusion from the place of God's presence of all who were not priests, of all who were not Jews."[22] Moreover, the tearing of the curtain also symbolized the end of the protection one had from dangerous encounters with God, who is no longer limited to sacred spaces and who radically changes those whom he encounters.

Mark describes a second response to the crucifixion from a Roman officer, who stood observing the scene and confessed, "Truly this man was God's Son!" (15:39). If there had been any doubt before, there need be none now. Jesus' death opened the door for non-Jews as well as Jews.

Furthermore, the confession says something about God as well. Jesus qua Son of God is the one who reveals God, and this happens at his death, not in

his exaltation or glorification. "The narrative seems to be emphasizing starkly that God is to be seen in this figure of powerlessness, weakness, and death."[23]

The final chapter of Mark has perplexed and intrigued scholars since it was written. The best manuscripts available to us testify that the Gospel ends with 16:8 and the account of the women leaving the tomb in terror and amazement, saying nothing to anyone, for they were afraid. The so-called shorter ending as well as the longer ending that includes 16:9–20 is missing from the earliest and most reliable manuscripts. The textual evidence as well as strong internal considerations argues in favor of verse 8 as the conclusion to the Gospel.

Interpreters must wonder: Was an ending torn off the manuscript at an early stage and lost? Did Mark intend to conclude the story with this somewhat bizarre finale? What is implied by an ending, which turns out not to be an ending at all? The best alternative is to acknowledge the problem and to read the Gospel ending at 16:8.

There have been a number of interpretations, the most plausible being that of Andrew Lincoln, who insists that verses 7 and 8 be taken together. In verse 7 the young man in white by the tomb makes a promise: "Go, tell his disciples and Peter that he is going ahead of you to Galilee; there you will see him, just as he told you" (cf. 14:28). The "terror and amazement" that overcame the women with the result that "fear" kept them from carrying out their assignment is a clear statement of disobedience. The divine messenger had commanded them to tell, but they said "nothing to anyone." And yet "the double irony is that they are to tell a promise that failure is not the end, but then *they* fail to tell and it *is* the end of the narrative."[24]

The promise, however, turns out to be "a promise of restoration after failure." The silence of the women, caused by their fear, was overcome by Jesus' word of promise. The sequence of promise, failure, and restoration becomes a powerful symbol in that it accounts for human disobedience and yet offers hope beyond failure.

Juel reminds us that the narrative cannot contain the promise. Mark forbids closure.

> The doors in Mark's Gospel are emphatically open: The curtain of the temple is rent asunder (as is the curtain of the heavens at Jesus' baptism) and the stone is rolled back from the tomb. There is surely disappointment as the women flee dashing hopes that at least one group of followers will prove faithful. But Jesus is out of the tomb: God is no longer safely behind the curtain. . . . The end is not yet, but the story gives good reasons to remain hopeful even in the face of disappointment. The possibilities of eventual enlightenment for the reader remain in the hands of the divine actor who will not be shut in—or out.[25]

16

The Gospel of Matthew

The Gospel of Matthew appropriately appears as the first book in the New Testament. It serves as a bridge connecting the two major divisions of the canon, and though there is a sharp division expressed between Matthew's community and the Pharisees, nevertheless, the text recognizes the necessary fulfillment of the Torah and functions as a fitting point of contact with Israel and Israel's history. In the first four chapters, there are five biblical citations introduced by the stereotypical formula, "This was to fulfill the words spoken through the prophet" (1:22; 2:15, 17, 23; 4:14). Furthermore, the Sermon on the Mount is headlined by Jesus' declaration, "Do not think that I have come to abolish the law or the prophets; I have come not to abolish but to fulfill" (5:17). God has achieved in Jesus those saving purposes previously recorded in the Jewish Scriptures. As Son of Abraham, as Son of David, as well as Son of God, Jesus is rooted in Israel's history and the fulfillment of Israel's heritage. He insists that "until heaven and earth pass away, not one letter, not one stroke of a letter, will pass from the law until all is accomplished" (5:18).

What can we say about the community to which Matthew wrote? It was likely a Jewish Christian group for whom the Scriptures were sacred. Alongside the fulfillment motif noted above, however, there is also a wholesale denunciation of the scribes and Pharisees (chap. 23), as well as an occasion in the Sermon on the Mount, when Matthew's readers are told that "unless your righteousness exceeds that of the scribes and Pharisees, you will never enter the kingdom of heaven" (5:20). Furthermore, when the parable of the Wicked Tenants is recorded in 21:33–44, the narrator comments, "When the chief priests and the Pharisees heard his parables, they realized that he was speaking about them. They wanted to arrest him, but they feared the crowds,